HIDDENATLAS

CURATED TRAVEL GUIDE

UNITED STATES · CALIFORNIA · NEVADA · ARIZONA

California and The American West

16 Day Road Journey

DESTINATION
United States, California · Nevada · Arizona

DURATION
16 Days • 15 Nights

IDEAL FOR
2–4 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

United States · California · Nevada · Arizona · 16 Days • 15 Nights

DAY 1
San Francisco

DAY 2
San Francisco · Coit Tower · Chinatown · Union Square · City Hall

DAY 3
San Francisco · Palo Alto · Napa Valley

DAY 4
San Francisco · Tuolumne Grove · Tunnel View · Yosemite Valley

DAY 5
Yosemite · Glacier Point · El Capitan · Vernal Fall · Sentinel Dome

DAY 6
Yosemite · Bakersfield · Las Vegas

DAY 7
Las Vegas · The Strip · High Roller · Eiffel Tower Experience

DAY 8
Las Vegas · Shooting Range · Fremont Street

DAY 9
Las Vegas · Page, Arizona · Horseshoe Bend

DAY 10
Page · Lower Antelope Canyon · Grand Canyon South Rim · Grand Canyon Western Ranch

DAY 11
Grand Canyon Western Ranch

DAY 12
Grand Canyon Ranch · Kingman · Hackberry · Los Angeles

DAY 13
Los Angeles · Venice Beach · Santa Monica

DAY 14
Los Angeles · Pacific Coast Highway · Malibu

DAY 15
Los Angeles · Beverly Hills

DAY 16
Los Angeles · Long Beach · La Jolla · San Diego

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- Yosemite Valley: Half Dome, El Capitan and Glacier Point from the valley floor
- Lower Antelope Canyon: the carved sandstone corridor where light behaves like water
- Grand Canyon Western Ranch: horseback riding, campfire and open sky in the canyon country
- Napa Valley's finest three wineries, including Chateau Montelena, which changed how the world understood California wine
- Helicopter over the Grand Canyon: the only way to understand the canyon's true scale
- Pacific Coast Highway through Malibu: the coastal drive that no route in the United States surpasses

DAY 1

Arrival in San Francisco

Land at San Francisco International Airport and let the city introduce itself at its own pace. The bay, the bridges, and the particular quality of afternoon light that makes San Francisco different from any other American city. The Embarcadero waterfront runs from the Ferry Building to Fisherman's Wharf, and the walk between them takes an hour if you are not stopping and a full afternoon if you are. The first evening is for the neighbourhood and a meal, not for sightseeing.

- San Francisco International Airport: arrivals connect directly to the city by BART in under thirty minutes
- The Embarcadero: the bayside promenade running from the Ferry Building north toward Fisherman's Wharf
- The Ferry Building: the restored 1898 terminal that became the finest food hall on the west coast
- Fisherman's Wharf: the working waterfront at the city's northern edge, best experienced early and without expectations

DAY 2

San Francisco — The City on Foot

A full day on foot through the city's most layered neighbourhoods. Coit Tower stands above North Beach, the art deco column offering the clearest view of the bay and the bridges from street level. The walk down through the city toward the Transamerica Pyramid passes through the former financial district and one of the more distinctive skylines in American architecture. Chinatown follows: dense, operational and one of the oldest in the country. Union Square marks the commercial centre. City Hall closes the day on a different note: the Beaux-Arts dome is larger than the Capitol in Washington, and the interior is among the finest civic spaces in the United States.

- Coit Tower: the art deco column above North Beach, with views north across the bay to Marin County
- Transamerica Pyramid: the pointed tower that defined the San Francisco skyline for fifty years
- Chinatown: one of the oldest and densest Chinese communities outside Asia, established in 1848
- Union Square: the commercial centre of the city, framed by department stores and the historic Westin St. Francis
- San Francisco City Hall: a Beaux-Arts dome larger than the United States Capitol, completed in 1915

DAY 3

Silicon Valley and Napa Valley

The morning drives south along the peninsula to Palo Alto, where the density of technology innovation per city block is unlike anywhere else on the planet. Apple Park's circular campus is visible from the road: a ring of glass and steel set in Californian native planting, the last project Steve Jobs oversaw. The Google campus in Mountain View is open to the footpath and the mood is campus rather than corporate. Both visits are brief by intention: the purpose is context, not tourism. The afternoon shifts register entirely. Three wineries, carefully chosen, are better than five by any measure: the decision to go fewer creates more room for each experience. Chateau Montelena put California wine on the world map at the 1976 Paris Tasting. Castello di Amorosa is a genuine Italian castle built over fifteen years in the Napa hills. Domaine Carneros makes Champagne-method sparkling wine on a hillside estate modelled on the Taittinger chateau in Reims.

- Apple Park: the circular campus visible from Tantau Avenue in Cupertino, Steve Jobs's final project
- Google Campus, Mountain View: the open technology campus on Amphitheatre Parkway, accessible on foot
- Chateau Montelena: the winery whose 1973 Chardonnay won the 1976 Paris Tasting, establishing California wine internationally
- Castello di Amorosa: a 121-room medieval Italian castle built by hand in the Napa hills, with cave-aged barrel rooms
- Domaine Carneros: the sparkling wine estate above Carneros, modelled on the Taittinger chateau in Champagne

INSIDER TIP

Three wineries is the right number for a single afternoon. The experience becomes less interesting after the third visit, and the drive back requires attention.

DAY 4

San Francisco to Yosemite

The drive east from San Francisco takes three to four hours, crossing the Central Valley farmland before the road climbs into the Sierra Nevada foothills. The first stop inside Yosemite is the Tuolumne Grove of Giant Sequoias: a short trail through old-growth forest to the largest living organisms by volume on earth. The trees are older than Christianity and wider at the base than most rooms. Tioga Pass, the high road across Yosemite's backcountry at 9,943 feet, operates only when clear of snow, typically from late May through November: when it is open, the views across the Sierra Nevada are among the finest in the range. The arrival into Yosemite Valley through the Wawona Tunnel ends at Tunnel View, one of the most reproduced vistas in American landscape photography. El Capitan and Half Dome frame the valley ahead.

- Tuolumne Grove of Giant Sequoias: a stand of ancient sequoias accessible by a short trail in the park's northwest sector
- Tioga Pass: the high mountain road at 9,943 feet, conditional on snow clearance, open late May through November
- Tunnel View: the panoramic overlook at the eastern end of the Wawona Tunnel, framing El Capitan and Half Dome
- Yosemite Valley: the seven-mile granite valley enclosed by walls rising up to 3,000 feet above the valley floor

DAY 5

Yosemite — The Valley and the Summits

A full day in the valley and above it. Glacier Point sits 3,200 feet above the valley floor and the view from the railing is one of the most complete perspectives of high-mountain granite in the western world: Half Dome directly ahead, the valley below, and the full arc of the Sierra Nevada range on a clear day. Back in the valley, El Capitan is best understood at its base rather than from a photograph: the 3,000-foot monolith that climbers have been ascending since 1958, and which is more impressive in person than any image suggests. Vernal Fall is reached by a trail from the valley floor, the spray from the fall heavy enough to soak through any layer above the footbridge. Sentinel Dome, a short walk from the road, provides a second elevated perspective as the afternoon closes.

- Glacier Point: the 3,200-foot overlook above Yosemite Valley, with views to Half Dome and the High Sierra
- Half Dome: the granite profile that defines the valley's eastern wall, visible from the valley floor
- El Capitan: the 3,000-foot monolith at the valley's western end, the most climbed big wall in the world
- Vernal Fall: the 317-foot waterfall on the Merced River, accessed via the Mist Trail
- Sentinel Dome: a shorter walk than Half Dome, with wide views across the western valley

DAY 6

Yosemite to Las Vegas

A long driving day that crosses the Central Valley and the Mojave Desert before the Nevada state line. The stop in Bakersfield breaks the journey at its natural midpoint: a working agricultural city with no pretension to tourism, which makes the lunch there feel honest in a way that a curated stop could not. From Bakersfield the road runs south and east through the Mojave, the landscape emptying out with a specificity that has its own logic. Las Vegas announces itself from the freeway before you arrive: the Strip visible in the distance as a lit structure set against the dark basin of the surrounding desert. There is no real preparation for the first arrival.

- Bakersfield, California: a Central Valley city known for agriculture and country music, used here as a genuine midday stop
- The Mojave Desert: the high desert basin between California and Nevada, at elevation through most of the crossing
- Las Vegas: the city reveals itself from the I-15 as a lit structure in an otherwise empty basin

DAY 7

Las Vegas — The Strip

The first full day in Las Vegas is structured around the evening. The Strip covers four miles from the Mandalay Bay in the south to the Stratosphere in the north, and the Mirage and the Venetian occupy its centre with the most interesting interior spaces on the boulevard. The Venetian's canal and Grand Canal Shoppes replicate something that is not quite Venice but achieves its own ambition with enough commitment to be worth the visit. The High Roller, at the Linq, reaches 550 feet and offers the best elevated view of the city at sunset from a slow-moving observation cabin. The Paris Las Vegas Eiffel Tower Experience after dark provides a different perspective: 460 feet of replica steelwork overlooking the Bellagio fountains at night.

- The Mirage: the resort that launched the modern Las Vegas era in 1989, with an artificial volcano erupting on the hour at night
- The Venetian: the canal and Palazzo complex at the centre of the Strip, with the Grand Canal Shoppes above the water
- High Roller at the Linq: 550 feet at the apex, the largest observation wheel in the United States, positioned for sunset
- Eiffel Tower Experience, Paris Las Vegas: the half-scale tower at 460 feet, overlooking the Bellagio fountains across the Strip

DAY 8

Las Vegas — The Range and Fremont Street

A looser day covering two different versions of Las Vegas. The morning is for the pool and no particular schedule. In the afternoon, a visit to Battlefield Vegas or one of the similar supervised shooting ranges gives access to a range of weapons under full instruction: an experience that is distinctly American and, for most visitors, unlike anything available at home. The evening is for Fremont Street: the original Las Vegas, before the Strip existed. The LED canopy runs for four blocks above the pedestrian mall, the casinos are older and cheaper and more interesting in their way than the megaresorts to the south, and the atmosphere is louder and less self-conscious.

- Pool morning: the large resort pools on the Strip are at their best before midday
- Battlefield Vegas: a supervised indoor shooting range with access to rifles, handguns and automatic weapons under instruction
- Fremont Street Experience: the covered pedestrian mall in downtown Las Vegas beneath a four-block LED canopy
- The Golden Nugget: the oldest and most historically significant casino on Fremont Street, opened in 1946

DAY 9

Las Vegas to Horseshoe Bend

The last morning in Las Vegas is unstructured by design. The Welcome to Las Vegas sign, the luxury retail on the Strip, walking the boulevard in daylight when the city reads differently: none of it requires planning. The drive east to Page, Arizona takes three and a half hours through the Mojave and into the Colorado Plateau, the landscape changing entirely as the red rock country appears on the horizon. Horseshoe Bend sits at the edge of the plateau two miles from Page: a 270-degree meander of the Colorado River 1,000 feet below the canyon rim, most rewarding in the hour before sunset when the light reaches the canyon walls from the west.

- Welcome to Las Vegas sign: the 1959 roadside sign a mile south of the Mandalay Bay, best photographed in the morning
- The drive to Page: three and a half hours east through the Nevada desert and into the red rock Colorado Plateau
- Horseshoe Bend: the 270-degree river meander 1,000 feet below the Glen Canyon rim, best at golden hour
- Glen Canyon National Recreation Area: the 1.25-million-acre protected landscape surrounding Lake Powell

DAY 10

Antelope Canyon, the Grand Canyon and the Ranch

Lower Antelope Canyon is the most visited slot canyon in the American Southwest, and with good reason. The sandstone walls have been carved by flash floods over centuries into narrow chambers where light is redirected and amplified in ways that are closer to architecture than geology. The canyon is 660 feet of passageway navigated on foot with a guide, and no photograph made before the visit fully prepares you for the colour and scale of the interior. Rainbow Bridge National Monument is not included in this route: it sits 50 miles by boat from Page, requires a separate day and advance arrangements, and does not fit naturally within the flow of this section. The afternoon drive southwest reaches the Grand Canyon's South Rim in two hours. Mather Point and Yavapai Point provide the first views into the canyon, a mile deep and ten miles across at its widest. Desert View, further east along the rim, adds perspective on the Colorado River below. The helicopter is the right way to understand the canyon's true scale: from the air, the depth and complexity of the gorge becomes readable in a way it never quite does from the rim. The road continues to the Grand Canyon Western Ranch as the light fails.

- Lower Antelope Canyon: 660 feet of carved sandstone passageway in the Navajo Nation, accessed with a Navajo guide
- Mather Point and Yavapai Point: the South Rim overlooks above the Inner Gorge, with the Colorado River visible a mile below
- Desert View: the easternmost South Rim overlook, with views into the canyon's deeper eastern section
- Grand Canyon helicopter: the most complete way to understand the canyon's scale and depth from above
- Grand Canyon Western Ranch: the ranch accommodation on the canyon's western plateau, reached as the light fails

DAY 11

Grand Canyon Western Ranch

A full day at the ranch with no itinerary beyond the land and the horses. The morning horseback ride takes the trails through juniper and pinyon desert at the canyon country's western rim, the horses setting a pace that the terrain dictates. The afternoon is unstructured: the shooting range, the trails on foot, the canyon air, whatever the day asks for. The campfire starts as the sun drops and continues into the dark. This is the part of the American West that the city visits cannot access: genuine distance from anything, a sky with no competition, and the particular quality of quiet that comes when there is nothing between you and the horizon.

- Horseback riding: guided trail rides through the canyon country desert at the western Grand Canyon rim
- Campfire at dusk: the western tradition at its most unmediated, with the canyon country dark around it
- Cabins and tent accommodation: the ranch offers both, the structures matching the surroundings rather than competing with them
- Optional activities: shooting range, hiking the surrounding trails, open sky above 6,000 feet

DAY 12

Route 66 to Los Angeles

Route 66 runs west from the canyon country through the high Mojave desert along the original highway alignment rather than the Interstate. Kingman is the first major stop: a railroad and mining city that thrived on Route 66 traffic, was bypassed by the Interstate, and was preserved in a state of useful authenticity in the process. The Hackberry General Store, 23 miles east of Kingman, is the best single stop on the Arizona section: a working general store, a classic car forecourt, and a collection of Route 66 memorabilia that feels lived-in rather than curated. From Hackberry the road continues west to the California border, then descends through the Cajon Pass into the Los Angeles basin, a three-hour drive that moves through three different climates and ends with the freeways of the San Bernardino Valley.

- Kingman, Arizona: the railroad city on the original Route 66 alignment, bypassed by the Interstate and preserved intact
- Hackberry General Store: the landmark roadside stop 23 miles east of Kingman, with classic cars and Route 66 atmosphere
- The Mojave crossing: the high desert section of Route 66 through the volcanic Hackberry Mountains
- Los Angeles arrival: the city comes through the San Bernardino Mountains and the San Fernando Valley

DAY 13

Venice Beach and Santa Monica

The first Los Angeles day establishes the city's register. Venice Beach in the morning: the boardwalk runs two miles along the edge of Santa Monica Bay, with the skate park, the outdoor weightlifting area and the street performers operating in an unofficial but highly organised ecosystem. Venice is not quite like anywhere else in Los Angeles, which is already saying something in a city where every neighbourhood operates on different rules. Santa Monica sits immediately north: the Third Street Promenade, the pier extending into the Pacific, and the cliffside park above the coastal highway providing the late afternoon setting. The Santa Monica Pier has been here since 1909 and carries the distinction of being the western terminus of historic Route 66.

- Venice Beach Boardwalk: the two-mile pedestrian strip with Muscle Beach, the skate park and street performers
- Abbot Kinney Boulevard: the Venice street of independent restaurants and design stores, a block from the boardwalk
- Santa Monica Pier: the 1909 structure extending into the Pacific, with the official Route 66 end-point marker
- Palisades Park: the cliffside linear park above the Pacific Coast Highway, with views across the bay to Malibu

DAY 14

Malibu and the Pacific Coast Highway

The Pacific Coast Highway runs north from Santa Monica through Malibu: 21 miles of two-lane coast road where the Santa Monica Mountains drop directly into the Pacific. The beaches along this stretch are among the best in Southern California and consistently less crowded than those to the south, the mountains keeping development close to the road and leaving the shoreline open. Point Dume sits at the headland north of Zuma Beach: a short walk above the tide line to the promontory with views south across the bay and north along the coast. The return can go via Malibu Lagoon State Beach at the pier, where Malibu Creek meets the Pacific and the brown pelicans work the surf line in the late afternoon.

- Pacific Coast Highway: the coastal route from Santa Monica north through Malibu, one of the finest drives in the United States
- Zuma Beach: the wide public beach north of Malibu Point, with consistent surf and open access
- Point Dume: the headland at the northern end of Santa Monica Bay, with a clifftop trail above the Pacific
- Malibu Lagoon State Beach: the estuary at Malibu Pier where Malibu Creek meets the ocean

DAY 15

Beverly Hills

Beverly Hills operates on a different scale from the rest of Los Angeles, which is itself a city of scale. Rodeo Drive runs three blocks from Wilshire Boulevard to Santa Monica Boulevard: the highest commercial real estate per square foot in the city, and one of the most photographed streets in the world. The Beverly Hills Hotel and the Polo Lounge behind it represent a particular mid-century Californian luxury that has survived intact across seven decades. The residential streets north of Sunset Boulevard, with their mature trees and their specific quality of quiet for a city this size, are best seen by a slow drive or on foot in the afternoon. A studio tour at Paramount or Warner Bros is the optional addition for those for whom Hollywood is more than geography: neither is essential to the day, but both are available within twenty minutes of Beverly Hills.

- Rodeo Drive: the three-block retail street that became a synonym for Californian luxury
- The Beverly Hills Hotel: the 1912 hotel with the Polo Lounge, a working piece of mid-century Californian atmosphere
- The Beverly Hills residential streets: the tree-lined grid north of Sunset Boulevard, best at a slow pace
- Optional: Paramount Studios or Warner Bros studio tour, for those for whom the studio system is a genuine interest

DAY 16

Long Beach, La Jolla and San Diego

The final day drives south from Los Angeles along the coast. Long Beach is brief but worth the stop: the Queen Mary, the British ocean liner that crossed the Atlantic for thirty years before being permanently docked in 1967, sits at the end of the harbour as one of the largest ships ever built. From Long Beach the freeway runs south through Orange County into San Diego, the last major city before the Mexican border. La Jolla sits on the coast north of San Diego proper: the sea caves at the cove, the sea lions on the rocks below, and the coastal walk above the Pacific providing a final encounter with the California coastline that the journey has been running alongside since Malibu.

- Long Beach: the port city south of Los Angeles, with the Queen Mary at the end of the main harbour
- The Queen Mary: the 1930s ocean liner permanently docked at Long Beach, now a hotel and landmark
- La Jolla Cove: the sea cave beach north of San Diego proper, with sea lions on the rocks and kelp beds offshore
- San Diego waterfront: the city's bayside promenade, with views across the bay to Coronado Island

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Ready to make this trip yours?

This guide gives you the structure and route.
Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
- Carefully selected areas to stay
- Logistics guidance for a smooth journey
- Insider tips from on-the-ground research

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